

Session 13: From Death to Life

Key Takeaways

- In the parallel movements of Ephesians 2 (2:1-10 and 2:11-22), we see the former predicament, the agents of death, God’s intervention, and the new creation result. The first movement shows the story from a cosmic perspective, and the second movement shows the story from a covenantal perspective.
- Identities that divide people are irrelevant because we have a new identity in Jesus.
- Ephesians 2:8 is not about the individual. Paul applies the verse to social relationships within a church community.

From the Living Dead to Membership in the Messianic Temple

Flow of Thought in Ephesians 2:1-22

This section contains two larger movements that are set in parallel. Each part begins by describing the dismal past of the letter’s non-Jewish readers and their move toward their new destiny in the Messiah. Each paragraph addresses their former, overlapping identities told in two stories.

- Ephesians 2:1-10: Their human identity within the cosmos, from death to resurrection life and rule [Gen. 1-2]
- Ephesians 2:11-22: Their gentile identity among the nations, from outsiders to God’s covenant people to one new messianic humanity [Isaiah]

Paul has designed each of these movements to run in parallel.

	2:1-10 Their story from a cosmic perspective	2:11-22 Their story from a covenantal perspective
Their former predicament	2:1-3: And you were dead in transgressions and sins, in which at that time (ποτε) you walked ... doing the desires of the flesh	2:11-12: Remember, at that time (ποτε), you nations in the flesh ... were estranged from the citizenry of Israel, foreigners of the covenants of promise, without hope and without God in the world
Movements in Ephesians 2. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).		

	2:1-10 Their story from a cosmic perspective	2:11-22 Their story from a covenantal perspective
The agents of death	2:2: “the ruler of the authority of the air, the spirit now at work in the sons of disobedience”	2:14-15: “the dividing wall, the hostility ... the Torah consisting of commands with decrees”
God’s intervention	2:4-8: But God, being rich in mercy ... made us alive together with the Messiah ... by grace you have been saved	2:13: But now in Messiah Jesus, you who were far have been brought near by the blood of the Messiah
The new creation result	2:5-6: He made you alive together with the Messiah ... and raised you up together and seated you together in the heavenly realm in the Messiah Jesus 2:10: You have been created in Messiah Jesus for good works	2:14-18: He made both groups into one ... in order that in himself he might create two into one new humanity ... through him we both have access by the one Spirit to the Father
<i>Movements in Ephesians 2. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).</i>		

He has also designed each movement to work by itself as a rhetorical symmetry so that the first half states the negative realities, which are then reversed in the paragraph’s second half.

Rhetoric	Ephesians 2:1-10	Ephesians 2:11-22
Negative past	2:1-2: You were dead in your transgressions and sin which, at that time, you walked in them	2:11-12: You were gentiles in the flesh ... without the Messiah, estranged from the citizenry of Israel ... without God in the world
Messianic transition	2:4-5: But God ... made you alive together with the Messiah	2:13-15: But now in Messiah Jesus you who were far away have been brought near by the blood of the Messiah ... to create the two into one new humanity
Positive present	2:10: You are ... created in Messiah Jesus for good works which God has	2:19: Therefore you are no longer estranged ... but fellow citizens and members of God’s household
<i>Rhetorical Symmetry in Ephesians 2. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).</i>		

Rhetoric	Ephesians 2:1-10	Ephesians 2:11-22
	prepared before hand, so that you would walk in them	
Rhetorical Symmetry in Ephesians 2. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).		

From Living Death to New Creation: Translation and Literary Design of Ephesians 2:1-10

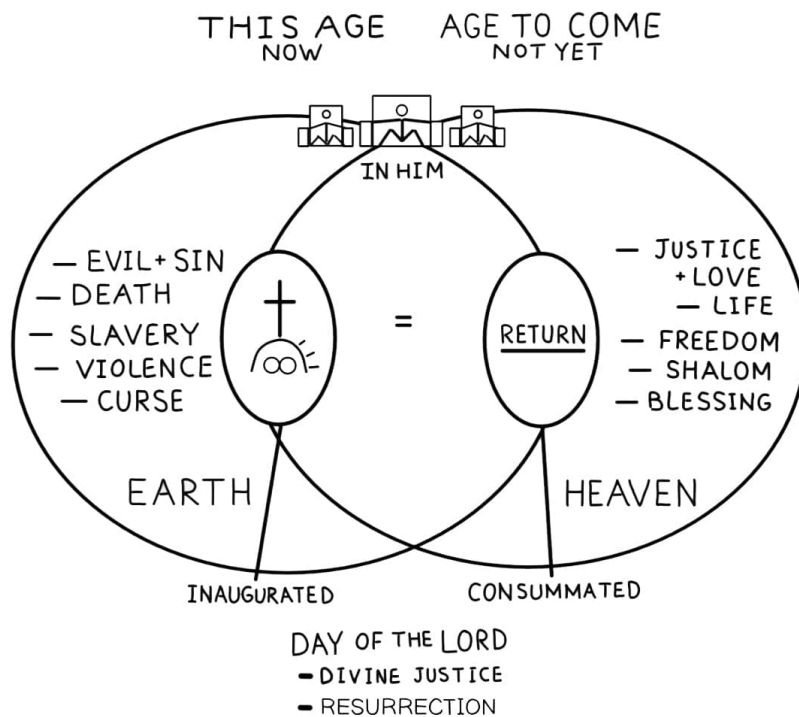
¹ And y'all, **being dead** in y'all's transgressions and sins,
² in which at one time y'all walked according to the **age of this world**,
according to the **ruler of the authority of the air**,
the spirit who is now working in the sons of disobedience,
³ among whom we also all used to live by the passions of our flesh,
doing the will of the flesh and the mindsets,
and we were by nature children of wrath,
as also were the rest.

⁴ But God, **being rich** in mercy,
because of the great love with which he loved us,
⁵ and we, **being dead** in our transgressions,
he **made us alive together** with the Messiah
—by grace y'all have been saved—
⁶ and **he raised us up together**
and **sat us together**
in the heavenlies
with Messiah Jesus
⁷ in order that he might demonstrate
in the ages which are coming
the surpassing richness of his grace,
by kindness to us in Messiah Jesus.

⁸ For it is by grace that y'all have been saved,
through trust,
and **this is** not from yourselves,
it is the gift of God
⁹ **[it is]** not from works,
in order that no one can boast.

¹⁰ For we are his handiwork,
having been created in Messiah Jesus
for good works
which God prepared beforehand,
so that we would walk in them.

Ephesians 2:1-10. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).



Jesus Enthroned on the Day of the Lord. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Paul's Letter to the Ephesians (2019).

Reflection Question

Ephesians 2:8 is often understood primarily as individualistic. Is that how you've read it in the past? In what ways has seeing this verse applied to social relationships within a community changed your understanding?